

THE FUNCTION OF THE EGO IN RELATIONSHIP TO THE REAL SELF

Greetings, my dearest, dearest friends. Blessings and guidance are extended so that each and everyone of you finds his path easier and reaches the goal with less struggle and resistance.

What is the goal? The goal, as far as man is concerned, can only be one thing, and that is becoming his real self. We approach this facet from many areas and angles.

Tonight I wish to discuss the inner self versus the outer self, or the real self versus the ego. What is their mutual relationship with one another? Much confusing theory exists about the function of the ego. There are those who say, or at least imply, that the ego is essentially negative and undesirable and that the spiritual goal is to get rid of the ego. And there are those, particularly in psychoanalytic thinking, who say that the ego is important. The scientific view is that where there is no ego, there cannot be mental health. These are two entirely opposing views. Which one is correct? Which one is false? Perhaps this lecture will shed some light on this important question. Even if you do not happen to think about such confusions because they do not consciously occur to you, they nevertheless blur your vision and hinder you from reaching the important goal of your self-realization.

Let us briefly recapitulate the essence of the real self. The inner person is an integral part of nature. It is bound to the identical laws of nature; and to distrust this innermost self is therefore unreasonable, for nature can be wholly trusted. If nature becomes man's enemy, it is only because man does not understand its laws. The inner self, or the real self, is nature; it is life; it is creation. It is even more correct to state it this way than to say it is a part of nature or creation. The real self and creation, or nature, are one and the same.

Whenever man functions out of his real self, he is in truth, he is in joy. The most creative and constructive contributions to life come from that inner self. Everything that is great and generous, everything that is life-expanding, beautiful, and wise comes from the inner or real self. We have said this many times, and it cannot be emphasized often enough, even in your own meditations. Trying to understand this truth, not only in your mind, but in your feelings, is essential.

Now then, my friends, if this is so, what then is the function of the ego, or the outer levels of personality -- those levels which are more accessible to you and those which you are more acutely and more directly aware of, that in you which thinks, acts, discriminates, and decides? The person whose ego has not sufficiently grown, whose ego is weak, is incapable of mastering or of coping with life. And he whose ego is overgrown and overemphasized cannot come to the real self. In other words, either extreme must hinder the reaching of the real self. Man's problems and conflicts are always a result of either too big an ego or too small an ego.

It cannot be said that one person has too big an ego and another too small or too weak an ego. Although this is so at times, as the presentation of an overall picture, most often it is rather that an imbalance exists, that one and the same person has an underdevelopment in one area of his personality, while in another there is an overdevelopment. In this way, nature tries to reestablish balance. The overdevelopment may be an attempt on the part of nature to straighten out the disturbance resulting from too weak an ego. Disturbance of harmony does not exist because of the attempt to reestablish it, but because of the original overemphasis or underemphasis, whichever the case may be.

It is a fact that only when the ego is sufficiently developed can it be adequately dispensed with. Whereas, so long as it is not developed, it cannot be dispensed with. Now, this may sound like a contradiction, my friends, but it is not. For, if the ego is underdeveloped, your not being in possession of a strong and healthy ego and wanting to make a virtue out of this lack is a weakness and evasion, which can only produce more weakness and lack. Anything that leads to the abundance of the true nature of life must happen out of abundance. As long as the ego is not strong enough, you lack something. You lack that faculty of your outer self which is necessary in order to think, discriminate, decide, act adequately, as you must when you deal in those dimensions which are a correspondence to the ego.

Anyone who strives to reach being his real self, to reach that stage of spiritual development, by pushing away the development of a healthy ego does so out of poverty. He does not yet own his outer self. Perhaps he knows that his outer self, or ego, is, in the last stages of being, no longer necessary. So he tries to skip the stage of creating a healthy ego -- out of laziness, due to finding it difficult to do so, and therefore hoping that this vital step can simply be avoided. But this error, like all errors, is costly. He actually delays reaching the goal. He will be thrown back until he does not avoid that which is necessary. Only when man is fully in possession of his outer self, his ego, can he then dispense with it and reach his real self.

This is a law. It is a logical law, for then man acts out of strength and abundance, not out of weakness, need, and poverty. Only when you are in possession of a strong and healthy ego -- not overgrown, not overemphasized -- can you use this ego in order to transcend it. Only when the ego is healthy and strong can you know that it is not the final answer, the final realm of being. You then use it in order to pass it, to transcend it, to reach a further state of consciousness.

To put it in very practical terms, in your work on this path, you learn, for instance, through your meditations to use all the faculties of your ego in order to reach beyond it. What you absorb from outside must first pass your ego faculties. You first reach out with your ego faculties. You first use them in order to state truths that you later experience on a deeper level of consciousness.

There are many human beings who do not realize that there is anything beyond the ego, whose final goal is to become a strong ego, whether or not it be thought about in just these terms. This then may lead to the distortion of an overego. This is a dead-end street, for the goal is directed in a wrong pathway, much too limited in scope and possibilities, so that instead of transcending and passing by this stage, such energies as are supposed to help in just this way are used to overaggrandize the ego.

The law that you have to reach a certain state and fully be in that state before it can be abandoned for a further state is extremely important to understand, my friends. It is often overlooked by man and, even more often, totally ignored. The importance of this law has not been made clear enough to mankind in spite of many truth-teachings -- either spiritual or psychological. This is one of the great, important laws for man to know and deeply comprehend.

In a variant form, the essence of this very law exists in the following facet. This very much belongs to the topic chosen for tonight. It is the function of the ego in relationship to the real self. The real self knows that the universe has no limitations; that, in truth and final reality, absolute perfection exists, attainable for each individual; that unlimited expansion of faculties and forces, in the universe as well as in the individual, make this perfection possible. When man becomes his real self, his Godself, and when he knows that he is part of nature and creation, he truly becomes Godlike, and in this sense, omnipotent, for he becomes master over all existing laws. Even if he has never heard of such philosophies, this is the final reality he deeply senses and yearns for. His innermost psyche, his innermost self, sends forth this ultimate fate, this potential of his life and being, this possible expansion in him.

The little child, at birth, does not yet possess an ego. Without the ego, it is possible to perceive this message from the real self quite clearly. But without the ego, the meaning of the message must be distorted. You have all not only heard from psychological orientations and teachings but found and experienced within yourself the childish striving for perfection, for omnipotence, for pleasure supreme, the ultimate bliss that knows no lack, no unfulfillment or frustration.

When there is no ego, these strivings are unrealistic, even destructive. You all have experienced in your pathwork that you first have to shed these desires or strivings before you can realize them and come to them all over again.

In other words, every one of you, my friends, who is on this path has to come to terms with the fact and has to accept his limitations as a human being before he can realize that he has an unlimited fount of power at his disposal. You all have to accept your own imperfections, as well as this life's imperfections, before you can experience that absolute perfection is your destiny that you must ultimately realize. But you can only comprehend and come to it after you have shed the childish distortion of this knowledge -- childish distortion because of a lack of ego. You all have to learn to let go of a desire for pleasure supreme and make do with limited pleasure before you can realize that absolute pleasure is your ultimate destiny. The doing with the lesser is an acceptance of this reality, of this dimension. For that, the ego faculties are necessary. Only when your ego deals adequately with the realm in which your personality, your body, now lives can you then deeply comprehend your real faculties, potentials, and possibilities.

When I speak of the ultimate aim of perfection, of limitless power, of pleasure supreme, I do not mean the realization of this in a distant future when you no longer possess a body. I do not speak of this state in a measure of time, but in a measure of quality that could be at any moment, at the moment when you awaken to truth. Awakening to truth is possible only when you have first found and then let go of the childish distortions of the message of utter perfection, utter power, and utter pleasure. In the underdeveloped ego, these desires are not only illusory, but selfish and destructive. They have to be abandoned before they can be attained.

This is the very same law that working out of abundance produces abundance, but working out of poverty and need produces more poverty and need. The weak ego considers itself annihilated when its wishes for omnipotence remain unfulfilled. Therefore the wish is negative. The healthy, strong ego knows the reality of being, without fearing that this state may not yet be realizable because of existing obstructions to the real self. The weak ego will clutch to laws and conditions of the little ego and thereby distort the greater laws. Out of need and weakness, it foregoes the strength and fullness that comes when ego faculties deal adequately with the immediate now and thereby transcend this immediate now.

My dearest friends, this lecture is of very great importance to all of you. It may be an important key not only to clear away the confusion regarding apparent contradictions in philosophic ideas about life, but what is even more important, you may find a very essential key to your own development. It may facilitate a letting go that can happen only when there is trust in this innermost self as an integral part of such a trustworthy nature and creation.

When you feel and experience this, you will not fear and therefore, overemphasize ego faculties. Nor will you leave important underdeveloped ego faculties slumber and untended.

Are there any questions, first regarding this topic?

QUESTION: Am I right in thinking that to be in a state of reality would be eventually an equivalent to being in a state of Godhood?

ANSWER: Yes, of course, but when this state is sought after artificially because the task of developing the ego seems to become too great, it is an erroneous way. The ego must be mastered. When I say the ego, I mean everything it has to deal with. Let us take an example. In a distorted view, the life of the outer man often is hard. Man has to work hard, he has to struggle for his survival and subsistence. Distortion and misconception has brought man to the state when this is unnecessarily the case. At the same time, man dreams of the state he will eventually find when struggle no longer exists, where only bliss exists. An erroneous way to come to this point is in an attempt at escaping the struggle. The struggle is a correspondence to the ego. Only after the struggle has been positively accepted, will it prove superfluous, and work and pleasure become one. But evading work, because of the struggle, leaves important potentials in the psyche and the ego untended, unexplored. After such acceptance, it is relatively quick that an individual discovers the truth of the end of tediousness in daily survival. It is then that he realizes the Godlike state to some degree, regarding this particular topic now chosen as an illustration.

QUESTION: About the overdeveloped and underdeveloped parts of the ego, would that be connected with overactivity in the wrong way, which is a result of an overdeveloped ego, while passivity, in an unhealthy manner, being a result of an underdeveloped ego?

ANSWER: Yes, that is correct. The functions of the ego further the state of becoming, while the real self is the state of being. Of course, it is misunderstood from man's vantage point that the state of being means no activity. But the activity is within the state of being. Activity and passivity blend as one harmonious cosmic movement.

QUESTION: Where I am unable to let go of my self-will and therefore unable to let go and trust in God, that is where my ego is overdeveloped. Where I fear self-responsibility, that is where my ego is underdeveloped. Is that correct?

ANSWER: Indeed. Where you do not dare to make your own decisions, where you lean on ready-made rules, there your ego is not sufficiently developed. And here you have a very good illustration of what I spoke of in this lecture: because of one distortion, an opposite distortion is created. Because your ego is underdeveloped in the mentioned areas, something in you tries to attain the selfhood you simultaneously deny when you refuse self-choice and self-responsibility. Only it does so by choosing the wrong way. Since the entire process occurs in blindness, in lack of awareness, the wrong way of attaining selfhood (self-will) is chosen instead of independent choosing. Concomitantly, your deep psyche feels that there should be a loosening up, and the clutching becomes a strain. It seeks to do so, again in the wrong way, by not taking hold of your ego in making your own decisions. You rather take those of others, in your obedience to rules.

QUESTION: I find it very difficult to let go of the dependency I feel towards any person possibly representing my father or my mother. I have been quite aware of this. But what you said tonight about the reluctance of letting go, and also the other thing, this childish desire for omnipotence, the dream for pleasure supreme -- this seems to me to be an important factor. I don't think I realized this sufficiently until today. Could you perhaps explain to me how these two act together, making it difficult for me to let go?

ANSWER: Now, of course, it is very important that in your work you find specifically in what areas you do not wish to give up omnipotence, pleasure supreme, and the ease the spirit longs for, where hardship does not exist with all its apparent difficulty of assuming responsibility. You yearn more for this state than you know. You do not want responsibility because it still appears a burden to you. You believe, in a corner of your being, that the childish state, where no adult responsibility exists, can be maintained by simply insisting that your parents continue to care for you. In your self-observations, you must find in what specific ways this manifests in your emotional reactions.

Then, as I said earlier, the connection is something deep inside of you which clamors to have all the childish wishes fulfilled. You do not want to give up any of these wishes, not comprehending on that level that, in this form, the wishes are unfulfillable. At the same time, on an equally deep inner level, you fear the consequences of this weakness and dependency. Therefore, as a weak and dependent person (inwardly), how can you afford to let go? For, the only way you appear strong in your own concept of yourself is by insisting, by not giving up and letting go. The weakness creates fear, and fear generates distrust. Therefore you cannot let go and give yourself up to the universal flow that will bring you into that state where the higher self attains these wishes on a different level. Therefore you must first determine to become a strong, self-responsible ego, an ego that is mature enough on all levels (and, of course, I emphasize that I speak of this inner level and not of you as a whole and outer person, for there are many levels where you are mature and self-responsible) to determine to give up the childish version of essentially realizable wishes. Beware of the feeling of resignation that you can never have any of that. Know that it exists. You will come to realize that when you give up the perfect dream, even what you have now will be so much better, so much more pleasurable. Meditate and pronounce the words in which you truly wish to give up but without

resignation, in a positive spirit that accepts good possibilities waiting even though the rigid, childish version is abandoned.

Part of this maturing lies in establishing clearly and specifically in what way you have caused a specific hardship, difficulty, or void. When meditation such as this is used, you will see that you become strong. You will then trust yourself. As you do so, this innermost self becomes a reality. Being part of life and creation, you will trust them all. Your distrust prevents you from giving yourself up, from letting yourself be. You must distrust yourself if you refuse to become a strong enough ego which adequately deals with the immediate issues around you. Do you now understand the connection?

QUESTION: I understand it. It is very clear. The only thing is that I feel, isn't it a long way one has to go, in the sense that one wants a certain experience or a certain pleasure or a certain power? And then I would say, must I accommodate myself to the present circumstances, or can I reach out for whatever I want?

ANSWER: Yes, you can and certainly should reach out. But you can adequately reach out only if you trust that it can happen, and let it happen. But you want to do it with your outer ego deficiencies. That is where the ego cannot adequately serve you. It is a gross misunderstanding of the functions of the ego. You use your ego where it cannot serve you, and you refuse to use it where it must serve you. You want to attain that pleasure with the limited scope and vision of the ego, with its limited possibilities rather than through letting that part of nature, life, and creation bring it to you in its own way. But you do not entrust it because you do not let go. And you can only let go of this part of your ego when you have understood these things and when you use the ego faculties in their proper way -- even in getting out of the way and claiming that different, higher functions fulfill their role for you. When this interplay is learned and lived with, self-trust grows, and therefore positive chain reactions between ego, real self, and universal forces are set in motion.

When you reach into the ego world with your ego faculties, you limit yourself. The reaching out into the universe must be done upon a decision of the ego, but not with ego limitations. You must reach into another realm. This is where the ego must be abandoned. This was the essence of this lecture. This giving up of the ego can happen only when you fully possess it.

QUESTION: Isn't the ego connected with self-will?

ANSWER: Indeed. False ideas, as well as self-will, are naturally a result of the ego world and not of the real self. But it is also the faculty of the ego to give up both. Only the ego can do so. The ego is necessary in order to change its own mind and intent. It is necessary in order to understand that it has a false idea, that it does not have self-will. It is up to the ego to maintain or abandon either of these two destructive facets. The ego alone is capable of exchanging the false idea for a truthful one. This means to let go of the tense, anxious self-will and replace it with a relaxed, free-flowing, flexible will functioning based on discriminating reasoning power, the call upon the intuitive levels of self, the choice for higher inner guidance of the real self.

QUESTION: I cannot visualize how the law of karma and heredity works and how the process of birth takes place. The baby, being born, and the soul -- does the soul exist before the baby is being born? How does that work?

ANSWER: Perhaps the best way for you to perceive these principles would be to think that the human body is a direct result of the personality, which of course exists previous to the baby's birth. The personality's thinking, attitudes, emotions, actions, all of these have their result in effects. The body with its environment, the life and life situation, the personal "fate" -- all these are effects of the mentality and personality and character. Not only your body, but your life conditions are a result of what you are. If you look at the question from this point of view, you will avoid a great deal of confusion. Karmic law, heredity, and specific conditions of birth are then no longer a problem. The way you now perceive it is something like this: a body is built by forces outside the personality. This creates confusion because such thinking occurs in a spirit of duality rather than the spirit of unity, where you perceive that you are an immediate result of yourself, including your body, your country, as well as every other factor in your life.

QUESTION: It is difficult to feel that.

ANSWER: Of course. You must not try to enforce such feeling. It will come by itself if you shelve this problem now, as far as feeling it is concerned. The more you comprehend cause and effect in your immediate life, where blindness in this respect still prevails, the more must extend the scope of inner inexperience about the self being the central cause of its life.

All of my friends still overlook very immediate links of cause and effect -- how you forfeit the results you wish, what the patterns and attitudes are that create certain undesirable conditions in your immediate life. As long as there is a veil over these links between cause and effect, it is impossible to feel the identical law over a wider time span.

QUESTION: I suffer from occasional heart palpitations which have no organic cause. I have found in my work that this is due to repressed guilt. Is there self-punishment involved?

ANSWER: Yes. It is self-punishment, at the same time fear of punishment, and at the same time also, fear of and resistance to giving up that which causes the guilt in the first place. You have made good progress in your work. Now if you uncover a level in which you do not want to give up any of the facets that create the guilt, you will have a profound understanding and experience of your basic problem. The self-punishment is a substitute for giving up the guilt-producing attitudes. By doing so, you unconsciously believe that it is possible to maintain these attitudes yet absolve yourself of the guilt. Therefore you go on punishing yourself, believing that this makes up for the fact that you do not give up the destructive patterns. If you say often enough how bad you are, if you suffer enough from your guilt, you feel you are still a nice person in spite of maintaining what is, in actuality, of no conceivable advantage to you and to others. The specific realization of this level will come to the degree that you truly wish to find it. Your ego faculties will help you to shed the guilt-producing patterns. Even if something in you doubts, you may do so in the understanding that at any time you have the right to reassume them should you so desire. This will strengthen your ego. Then you will succeed. You will no longer be a helpless prey. You then take hold of yourself by using your ego in its proper way.

Bring your personal problems, my friends. We can go into them more deeply at the question-and-answer-sessions. You will surely profit from such participation.

All the blessings are extended to every one of you. These blessings are a reality that transcend and envelop you. They are the universal love, responding to your valiant efforts of self-expansion. Be in peace, be in God!

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